

how hard we tried. Photo images weren't very good, and looked the most aliased and pixelated from amongst all the players. In terms of performance, all three DVD players are similar, making the model designations hardly significant (considering the very similar features), and quite simply put, your money is better spent elsewhere.

Further down the line, two Philips players attracted us with their looks. The build quality that this brand imparts has to be seen to be believed. Smooth, brushed metal, attractive steel grey powder coating, sleek as a wind tunnel-designed thoroughbred, both the DVP3136 and the DVP5150X will draw at least a cursory glance, and that's while switched off, although the latter is a better looking player. With sleek remote units, that look as good as they function (Ah, the joys of soft, yet firm buttons). Philips has got aesthetics covered to be sure. What we did miss was any sort of PC display connectivity (there's no VGA). A new incorporation from Philips has been support for DivX Ultra, basically a standard for compatibility of various DivX standards as far as subtitles, sound channels and even the encoded video go. Besides Philips none of the brands in this test had support for this new and emerging standard. Both the players have



Onida Candy

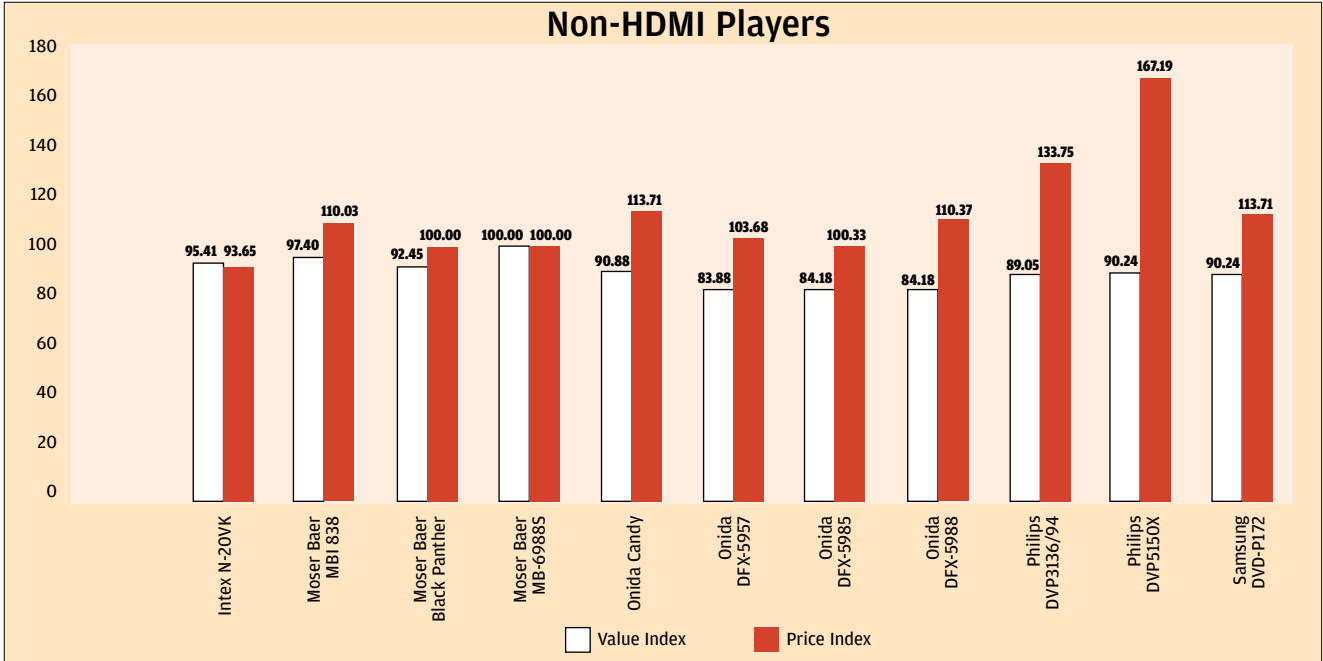
no support for USB or memory cards, but performed quite well, and a few niggles aside, both make for good components in a home entertainment setup. Although the DVP-5150X costs a thousand rupees extra, besides the outer body finish, this isn't really noticeable in any way once both get working. The DVP-3136 also supports Hindi as a setup language—a boon to be sure for people who are more comfortable with it. The stereo channels have spring clips, and not RCA ports. Both these players performed very closely to the leaders of the pack—the Candy and Black Panther—although the difference in quality won't be noticeable unless you have both players running and are discerning enough. At Rs 3,999 and 4,999 for the DVP-3136 and DVP-5150X respectively, economy you will not get; which is the only blemish on an otherwise nearly spotless report card.



Samsung's DVD-P172 was the only player from the Korean giant in this category. The quality of plastics used is top notch. The entire dark grey / black and silver tone goes well, this player suits nearly any décor. We liked the soft-buttoned remote control which Samsung claims will work with any of their flat-screen displays as well. Even the DVD tray exudes quality, a nice slow action, not a jerky motion like most other players. The LED panel has a soft light that is quite easy on the eyes, while retaining legibility. Like the Philips players Samsung also does without memory card and USB connects. In terms of performance, Samsung's DVD playback quality was as good as we've seen in this category, while VCD quality wasn't a touch behind what we'd call *really* good. With a good showing on the performance front, a good price—Rs 3,400—and undeniably good looks, the DVD-P172 makes for a good buy especially if both the best performers' looks fail to inspire you.

Our Choice

Our *Best Buy* award goes to the Intex N-20VK. Excellent value for money at Rs 2,800, it's well built, reasonably feature-rich and a decent performer. If you're on a shoestring, here's your player. Our best performer in this cat-



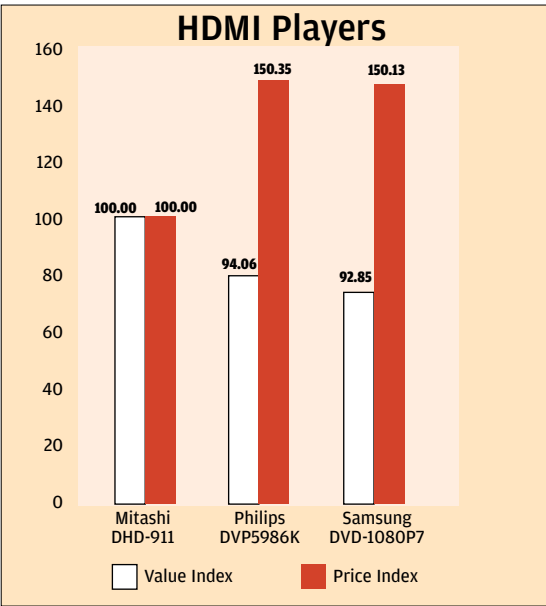
egory is the Onida Candy. A sterling little performer at Rs 3,400 with funky looks that will definitely attract attention (even if it's the wrong kind). Some may think it garish, some may think the design's weird, but it puts its critics to rest when you fire up any sort of compatible movie. Moser Baer's Black Panther also deserves mention here. It's a little more sober than the eye catching Candy, and marginally trails on the performance front. For Rs 2,990 the Black Panther most definitely deserves to prowl our markets and makes a very good buy if you should decide on something better performing than the N-20VK but cheaper than the Candy.

HDMI Players

This category consisted of just three players spanning three brands. HDMI and HD are big buzzwords in the market—everybody looking for a home entertainment system wants to ride the wave. Very little is known, however, about HD content, and just like any technology in its nascent stages of early growth HD isn't without its fair share of

niggles. On the PC, players like VLC make short work of playing any HD video regardless of resolution or file format, DVD players (even 1080p-supporting DVD players) had issues. Sadly, HD content on these players will only play if the file (mostly AVI format) is actually encoded in a supported HD resolution like 720p (1280x720 pixels, progressive scanned) or 1080i (1920x1080 pixels, interlaced). If the file is encoded at any other resolution, however minute the difference, the DVD player will cough up an error. Since HD videos are best enjoyed on a digital output signal, HDMI is the preferred connect when viewing any high definition content. Note that the HDMI connect will also carry audio signals, and you have to use your television's audio out to route these to the necessary speakers.

Mitashi's DHD-911 is a rather plain looker made a little better by the proud brand name embossed on to the top metal cover. The remote control was anything but plain—grey body with bright blue buttons—a little gaudy but we liked it. Buttons



are reasonably soft, imparting good positive feedback during use, and the unit works flawlessly at a distance of 12 feet. Connectivity wasn't on short supply either with the usual HDMI, S-Video, Composite, Component and audio RCA being accompanied by both USB and Memory card support. This would have to be Mitashi's highlight—the sheer connectivity options, and the other advantage we see is the transparency of settings in the setup menu, very similar to the Moser Baer Black Panther. So what's the downside here—performance? No! The DHD-911 is an excellent performer, and is highly recommended for any sort of DVD- or HD-viewing—especially at the bargain price of Rs 3,990—it's a lot of player for the money spent.

Philips' DVP5986K was the second HDMI ready player we tested and it had quite a few tongues hanging out with its design. The remote was suitably curvaceous and functional for all its looks. For once Philips, dropped in a USB slot—very appreciated. Another nifty feature is the addition of an audio in for karaoke. DivX Ultra support is another little bonus, though it's not of much use right now. We'd have liked separate RCA audio outs (useful for floor-standing speakers) and an optical out—neither was available. Comparing the DVP5986K to the DHD-911 proved interesting—the former is definite-

Decision Maker

If you're looking for:

A cheap DVD player that performs adequately then look no further than our *Best Buy* award winner, the Intex N-20VK. At Rs 2,800 and with a good feature set and performance to boot we'd guarantee satisfaction here.



Something that's connected, and HDMI and digital audio are your primary needs, but at the same time the player should perform well and equally importantly look good, then Samsung's DVD-1080P7 will easily do the trick. With sleek supermodel looks and the performance of a thoroughbred you can't go wrong with this player. Add to that a sweet price of Rs 5,990 and this is your best bet. Did we mention it's our performance winner in the HDMI player category?



No hassles, a DVD player with complete surround setup. The Moser Baer MBI AV 780 will surely satisfy. It's got oodles of performance, is reasonably feature rich, and comes complete with subwoofer and punchy satellites all for a modest price of Rs 7,490



Something portable that plays DVDs, and not a PMP. We just may have what the doctor ordered! LGs DP271D is a very compact fully functional DVD player with a very cute remote, and an eight inch LCD screen. Its powerful loudspeaker is much better than any PMP and with two headphone jacks it's a cinematic experience for two. The good battery life is a plus, and with a number of settings available and very acceptable performance the DP271D bears our highly recommended moniker. The price—Rs 8,490 makes this device an absolute steal. Just remember to carry your DVDs safely!

